

Telepresence Redefines Remote Meetings

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Telepresence meeting room (Image courtesy: www.saitron.com)

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Teleconferencing bridges the communication gap for individuals at distant locations. A teleconference is also referred to as a tele-seminar and audio conferencing. It is an upgraded telephone meeting with a more sophisticated technology than a simple telephonic meeting. If conducted with the facility of video images, it is also referred to as videoconferencing.

Unfortunately, with most teleconferencing options, eye-to-eye contact—the key element of effective communication—is lost due to poorly placed cameras.

Telepresence technology bridges this gap to provide real-time experience of meetings.

What is telepresence?

Telepresence refers to a set of conferencing technologies that uses telero-

botics to allow a person or a group of members to feel—via a video conference—as if they are present in the meeting room while, in fact, being at a remote location—locally or around the world. It is not just video conferencing. Immersive telepresence systems redefine the meeting experience. From the feeling of entering the room to the sensation of being at the same table and simplicity of starting a meeting, the focus is solely on the experience of the participants.

With this new way of working, everyone, everywhere can be more productive through face-to-face interaction and collaboration. It gives people the provision to be there while being here.

How does it work

Telepresence senses the participants' position, movements, actions, voice, etc. The sensed information is trans-

mitted to and duplicated in the remote location to bring about the effect of being present in a meeting. Thus it facilitates timely sharing of business and life-altering views and information, beyond geographical boundaries and time zones. Telepresence is a very high standard of technical sophistication that leads to the highest possible level of videotelephony.

Tandberg, now part of networking giant Cisco, is a fast-growing company in the telepresence and video conferencing field. Cisco's TelePresence system is based on the creation of special meeting rooms that are equipped with high-resolution plasma monitors displaying all the attendees that participate in the meeting. Additionally, an integrated VoIP phone line guarantees high-quality audio communication.

The technology behind Cisco's TelePresence system is seamless. According to Cisco, it requires minimal training of the end users. They simply have to access a calendar system, set up a meeting room in one click and the system will automatically send an invitation to the VoIP phone available in the telepresence locations.

Some other Cisco telepresence systems are T3, 3010 and T3 custom edition. The T3 is an exclusive forum for natural communication. The consistent room design and lighting create openness while participants appear almost 3D. The 3010 allows six people to connect with up to 48 locations. With T3 custom edition, the telepresence experience is not confined to the meeting room. It is accessible in a wider variety of unique settings and applications—from auditoria and informal